

A diplomatic trip lands Wu on a bigger stage

On eve of second term, Canada travel magnifies her role as Trump critic

By Emma Platoff
GLOBE STAFF

HALIFAX, Nova Scotia — First up, an early interview with NBC10 Boston. Then, meetings and more press at City Hall. Midday, an event in the historic public square to honor veterans.

It seemed a typical Tuesday for Mayor Michelle Wu. Only she was hundreds of miles from her concrete office in Boston’s brutalist seat of government, and the cloudy gray coastal city where she was carrying out her official duties was flying a maple leaf flag, not the Stars and Stripes.

Fresh off her reelection to a second term, Wu spent three days asking questions, holding meetings, shaking hands, and posing for pictures north of the border in this Canadian province. The official reason for her visit: retrieving a 45-foot white spruce Christmas tree for Boston Common, an annual gift to thank Boston for its swift help after a deadly 1917 explosion in Halifax.

But unofficially, the tableau was inescapably political: an international stage for a blue city mayor whose sharp rebukes of President Trump have

WU, Page A13

Last loss to Collins still haunts Democrats
Maine primary tests electability question

By Sam Brodey
GLOBE STAFF

ROCKLAND, Maine — The shadow of the last candidate who tried to knock off longtime incumbent Republican Senator Susan Collins still haunts Maine Democrats — those who remember her, anyway.

At a recent town hall event for Democratic candidate Graham Platner, Jenna Campbell, a data analyst from Bath, seemed at a loss when the Globe referred to the ill-fated 2020 candidate.

“I don’t even remember who it was,” she said.

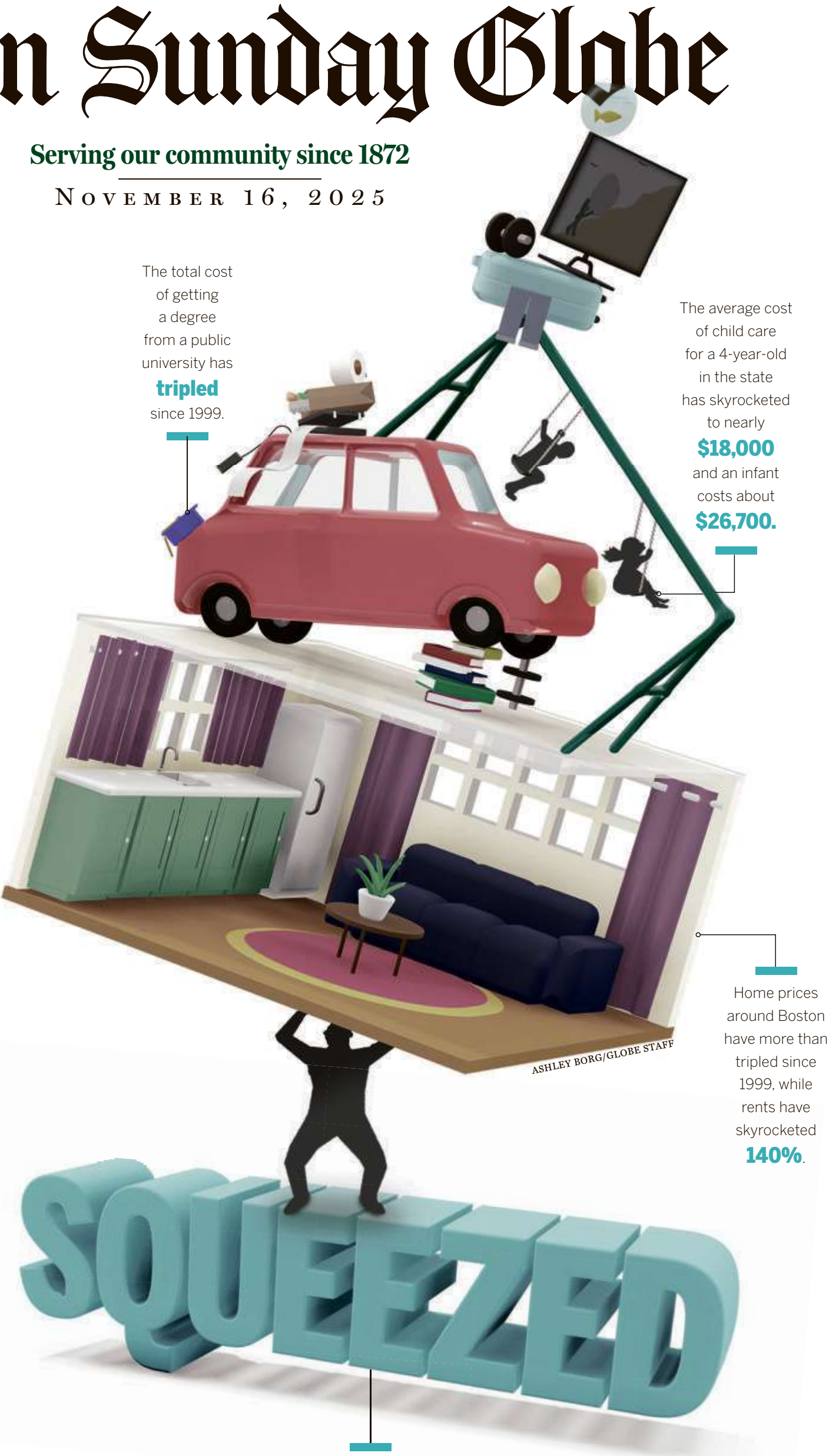
It was Sara Gideon, the former speaker of the Maine House of Representatives and the top recruit of Senate minority leader Chuck Schumer that year. She and outside Democratic allies sought to focus the race on Collins’s role in national politics, spending tens of millions of dollars to paint her as a feeble enabler of President Trump and GOP leadership.

Democrats believed the backlash nationally to Trump and Collins would be enough to power that message, despite misgivings with Gideon as a candidate, and public polls

MAINE, Page A8



Susan Collins won a Senate seat in Maine in 1996, and has typically been reelected easily ever since.



From secure to struggling:
The unraveling of the middle class in Massachusetts

By **Esmy Jimenez, Aaron Pressman,** and **Mara Kardas-Nelson** | Globe Staff

Alexa Arena, a 35-year-old college-educated professional, moved in with her parents to save on rent. Though she works full time, the classic trappings of a middle-class life — the kind she had growing up — now feel out of reach. “I don’t even know what the middle is anymore,” she said. “I’ve been living basically paycheck to paycheck.”

Lynn Handly, 61, a state worker living in Brockton, began living alone for the first time after her children moved out of the house and she got a divorce. She felt a sense of freedom for a while, but is now left worrying about retirement. “People think when you work for the state, you’re spoiled, but you’re not,” she said. (The Globe is using Handly’s middle and maiden names for fear of reprisal by her employer.)

Sasha White, 33, a public school music teacher who lives in Dorchester and owes \$123,000 in student loans, carefully juggles each of her household bills. She feels too close to the edge of a financial cliff not to. “Student debt, I put that on the back burner for now,” she said.

‘The only thing that I take care of are things that are going to immediately come after me.’

All three women make enough money to be considered middle class — a status that once conferred financial security, even a measure of comfort. The ability to buy a house and a car. Pantries stocked and utilities paid each month. Enough left over to take an occasional vacation, maybe help their kids with college and with a downpayment on a starter home. But those days are gone.

SQUEEZED, Page A10

Along border, local police caught in deportation debate

Critics say patrol partnership compromises officers

By Paul Heintz
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

As chief of the Swanton Village Police Department, Matthew Sullivan spends much of his week focused on the routine police work that makes his northwestern Vermont town safe.

But just about every weekend, Sullivan drives his department-issued cruiser to a nearby US Border Patrol station to clock in for a very different shift: patrolling the Canadian border on behalf of the federal government.

Depending on the agency’s

needs that day, he may ply a 24-foot patrol boat along the maritime border on nearby Lake Champlain, or he may monitor a rural road where migrants have been spotted crossing from Canada into the US. If he sees something suspicious, he calls in Border Patrol.

Sullivan’s weekend work is part of Operation Stonegarden, a federal program that provided \$81 million last year in overtime pay and equipment to local, county, and state law enforcement agencies in exchange for their help protecting the international border.

In the two decades since it

BORDER, Page B9

“The American Revolution” from Ken Burns rewards slower viewing, says critic Chris Vognar. **SundayArts, N1.**

I’ll leaf you to it

Sunday: Cloudy, windy. High: 52-57. Low: 33-38.
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